

Determiners

DETERMINERS ARE ALWAYS PLACED BEFORE A NOUN, AND HELP TO DEFINE IT.

Articles are determiners, and other determiners work in much the same way: They are used in front of nouns to indicate whether something specific or something of a particular type is being referred to.

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Determiners and adjectives

Determiners are often considered to be a subclass of adjectives and, like adjectives, they belong to nouns and modify nouns. Unlike adjectives, there is rarely more than one determiner for each noun, nor can

determiners be compared or graded. They precede the noun and include words like *several*, *those*, *many*, *my*, and *your*, as well as articles (*the*, *a*, and *an*) and numbers.

The determiner always precedes any adjectives, which, in turn, precede the noun.

several furious members

adjective

plural noun

• Many sentences do not make sense without determiners.

Adjectives, by contrast, are optional; they color the words rather than glue them together.

• Most noun phrases only use one determiner, but there are exceptions: for example, “all the bats” and “both my cats.”

Several furious members of **the** broomsticks. “**That** witch has **nine**

definite article

GLOSSARY

Cardinal number A counting number such as *one*, *two*, or *twenty-one*.

Linking verb A verb such as *be* that joins the subject of a sentence to a word or phrase—often an adjective—that describes the subject.

Ordinal number The form of a number that includes *first*, *second*, and *twenty-first*.

Demonstrative determiners

Demonstrative determiners give an idea of distance between the speaker and the person or thing that he or she is referring to. *This* (singular) and *these* (plural) are used to describe things that are nearby. *That* (singular) and *those* (plural) are used for things that are farther away.

This indicates a witch who is not present at the meeting.

that witch

The witches are discussing a noise they can hear—that of shrieking bats—so *this* is used.

this noise